Case study: choosing your refund after a train ticket is cancelled

cnftkt (train booking app) | Owner: Rahul | Status: Draft v1 | Prototype: https://www.figma.com/design/JUV43pU88beHhbOJMktsMj

1. The problem

When a train ticket is waitlisted, cnftkt asks where a refund should go (wallet or original payment source) right after booking, about 30 days before travel, and the answer can't be changed. If the ticket is cancelled just before the journey, users can wait up to 7 working days for money they need now. The wallet is instant and withdrawable, but many users avoid it, partly from a fear of locked money.

Real case: a student's waitlisted ticket (about ₹2,700) was cancelled automatically 8 hours before travel. His refund was locked to the bank by his booking-time choice, and he had no spare cash to rebook. A friend faced the same. This is a small sample, to be broadened in interviews.

2. What I found

Teardown. Strengths: the alternate travel plan, an easy interface, and showing chances of confirmation. Broken: refund choice locked at booking, a coupon that can't be used until the original train departs, few people knowing about the alternate plan, and a first screen crowded with ads. I scored them on reach, pain and ease of fixing, and chose the refund problem first.

Competitors. In IRCTC and RailOne I observed no refund choice, and MakeMyTrip's train choice is unconfirmed. cnftkt is the only one with an instant, withdrawable wallet for train refunds. So the gap is not a missing wallet. It is that nobody asks at the moment of cancellation. This covers three apps, so it needs a second look.

3. What users told me

Interviews are in progress. Findings will go here as: insight, a real quote, and how many of the 5 people said it. Until then, the only evidence is my own case and one friend's, and I treat the rest as assumptions to test.

4. What I'd build

When a waitlisted ticket is cancelled, the app sends an alert and shows a choice screen: cnftkt wallet (instant, withdrawable anytime) or original payment source (up to 7 working days). Neither option is pre-selected, and the booking-time question is removed for waitlisted tickets. Proposed, not yet confirmed with the technical team: the refund stays on hold until the user chooses, with reminders, and a time limit may be needed so the wait never exceeds today's 7 days.

5. How I'd measure it

- **Main metric:** wallet opt-in rate = users who choose the wallet ÷ users shown the choice after cancellation. The baseline is unknown.
- **Guardrail:** refund-related support contacts per 1,000 cancellations. It should stay flat or fall.
- **Main assumption to test:** choosing after cancellation raises wallet use more than the booking-time line does. An A/B test plan is the next document.

6. How I'd decide what's next

Now: the refund choice, and stating the coupon rule clearly. Next: making the alternate plan easier to find, and sharing the first screen between ads and main features. Later: letting the coupon be used early (I first need to know why the rule exists), suggesting the last choice, and a refund tracker. Scores are my gut feel, and the interviews will update them.

7. What I learned and what I'd do differently

- I corrected my own assumption mid-project. I first thought every booking asked the refund question at booking, but only waitlisted tickets do. Confirmed tickets already show the choice at cancellation, so the fix extends a pattern the app already uses.
- The moment of a decision matters as much as the options. The same choice is easy to ignore a month early and valuable at the time of need.
- Next time I would run the interviews earlier, check how each ticket type behaves before writing the PRD, and take screenshots as I go.